

OXFORD

INTERNATIONAL
AQA EXAMINATIONS

INTERNATIONAL AS LEVEL PSYCHOLOGY

(9685) PS01 Introductory Topics in Psychology
Report on the examination

June 2023

REPORT ON EXAMINATION: INTERNATIONAL AS LEVEL PSYCHOLOGY 9685 PS01 JUNE 2023

General Feedback

Performance on this exam was comparable to previous series, with some students demonstrating excellent psychological knowledge and understanding. Overall, students performed better on questions requiring AO1 skills, but did not often achieve the same level of success on questions that required AO3 skills. For these AO3 questions, students tended to identify relevant evaluation issues but did not follow these up with effective elaboration. Alternatively, when elaboration of the issue was provided it tended to be generic and not explicitly linked to the material they were evaluating. On several questions, students did not focus on any providing any creditworthy evaluation of the issue and instead wrote lengthy descriptions of research (eg Asch or Milgram.) They failed to use these studies in an evaluative way and therefore gained little to no credit. Students need to focus on their evaluative skills and highlight the importance of revising their evaluations thoroughly so that they can use them in an effective way.

AO2 skills continue to show some development. Many students were able to effectively use their knowledge and understanding and to apply this in a successful way to the novel scenarios presented in the paper. Alternatively, some students continue to struggle with these AO2 questions by writing their responses without engaging and linking to the scenario given, or by simply rewriting large sections of the scenario within their response. This often resulted in very few marks being gained.

QUESTION 01

This question was answered well by most students. Many were able to provide a clear and elaborated description of two different components of the working memory model. The best responses focused on providing thorough detail, often highlighting two different pieces of information that they knew about their chosen component. An alternative approach was taken by some students, who provided a detailed and effective elaboration of a single piece of information for each component. Both were effective ways to answer this question. The main issues holding some student's responses back were in relation to the lack of clarity and/or detail in their descriptions, eg simply stating that 'the central executive is the overall controller of the working memory model'. Responses of this limited nature could only gain 1 mark.

QUESTION 02

Many students performed well on this question which involved an AO1 and AO2 split in the marks. Some only named the three types of long-term memory and this was not enough to gain the AO1 credit as the question's command word was to outline the three types. Therefore, students needed to provide some AO1 information about each type of long-term memory. Many were able to successfully apply the types of long-term memory to the relevant elements within the scenario about Lee and James. The majority could correctly identify the procedural type of long-term memory. There was however some confusion related to the episodic and semantic types of long-term memory.

QUESTION 03

It was pleasing to see that most students attempted this question with many demonstrating good knowledge of the multi-store model of memory. However, it was often the evaluation (AO3) skills that let students down as it was of a very mixed quality. Some were able to provide several clear, effective, and well elaborated evaluation points about the MSM which gained high level 3 and level 4 responses. Alternatively, others spent too long on producing very lengthy descriptions of the multi-store model and related research studies. This often resulted in shorter and less effective evaluations. Students must remember that there is an uneven split in AO1 and AO3 skills within 20-mark essays. Therefore, they must ensure that they spend an appropriate amount of time within their answer on effective evaluations. Some students used studies, eg Peterson & Peterson, to highlight aspects of the

multi-store model. These were often used ineffectively with too much focus on AO1 (lengthy descriptions of how the research was conducted), rather than how and why the study supports the multi-store model. Students who used these studies effectively often provided a short summary of the research procedure and then proceeded to use the findings as effective evaluation for the multi-store model to support the existence of the different components of the model.

QUESTION 04

Most students did well on this question and could accurately identify the two statements that described compliance.

QUESTION 05.1 and 05.2

Many students performed well on both questions, scoring at least 2 out of 3 marks. More students were able to gain the full 3 marks on question 05.2 compared to 05.1. To obtain all 3 marks, the descriptions of normative and informational influence needed to be clear and somewhat detailed with appropriate use of specialist terminology. Students were routinely able to provide clearer descriptions of normative influence compared to informational influence. For normative influence, students would demonstrate a greater understanding of the concept, often offering clear and effective examples. However, the same level of clarity and detail was not given for informational influence.

QUESTION 05.3

Students seemed to struggle with this question, with a surprising number simply not attempting the question at all. Many students were unable to move out of level 1 or low level 2 responses due to not engaging fully with the question and clarifying how and why their chosen evaluation issues were either strengths or limitations for the explanations for conformity. Additionally, many simply provided lengthy descriptions of Asch's research. Unfortunately, this was not used effectively as they did not attempt to explain how and why Asch's research can be used to evaluate normative and/or informational explanations of social influence, eg that Asch found, through interviews with his participants, that some conformed due to not wanting to be the odd one out (supporting normative influence), whilst other naïve participants genuinely thought the rest of the group were right (supporting informational influence). Students also favoured the use of methodological evaluations of studies, however they did not explain how and why these methodological issues, both good and bad, were related to the overall issue at hand, which was to evaluate the explanations for conformity, as opposed to evaluating the way the studies were conducted.

QUESTION 06

Most students were able to provide a low level 2 response for this question, but only a small number were able to gain the full 4 marks available. Many could use their knowledge of social support and apply this to Jemina's behaviour. However, this was not always done in a sufficiently clear and detailed way, with effective use of specialist terminology, resulting in a low level 2 mark. A common aspect of social support that was often overlooked by students is how the other person, who is initially resisting social support (in the case of this scenario if was one of Jemina's friends), acts as a model for others (in this case Jemina), which makes it easier for someone to resist as well, through increasing confidence to speak out, etc. This element seemed to be lacking in the knowledge of students.

QUESTION 07

Many students seemed to struggle with this question. Only a small minority were able to provide a level 4 response, with most being unable to move beyond level 1 or low level 2 responses. The main issue was that many students were unable to demonstrate an understanding of legitimacy of authority as an explanation of obedience. Instead, it appeared that they saw the word 'obedience' in the question and proceeded to write lengthy descriptions of Milgram's research which gained little or no credit. Some students also wrote lengthy explanations of agentic state which is a completely different

explanation of obedience. Overall, most students were able to secure some AO1 marks by providing some limited understanding of legitimacy of authority. However, the evaluations provided to support or criticise legitimacy of authority were either poorly developed or simply not relevant. Moving forward, this is an area of the social influence content that students need to clarify.

QUESTION 08

Most students could accurately name one of the four definitions of abnormality to gain the single AO1 mark. However, accuracy of the name is important since all four definitions are clearly named on the specification. Some students invented terms which were not creditworthy. The second part of this question required students to apply their knowledge of their chosen definition to Fahad's behaviour. Most were able to gain 2 out of 3 available AO2 marks. The main issue was the lack of explicit application. Instead of explaining their chosen definition in the context of Fahad's behaviour, many students provided detailed explanations of their definition of abnormality using generic examples and links to abnormal behaviours.

QUESTION 09.1

The command word 'outline' was overlooked by many students here as most simply stated classical and operant conditioning, which only gained a maximum of 1 mark. Students should be made more aware of the various command words that can be used within examinations. The best answers to this question highlighted that phobias are learnt/gained via classical conditioning (1 mark) and that a phobia is maintained via operant conditioning (1 mark).

QUESTION 09.2

This question was another AO3 skill only question and, consequently, many students struggled once again to gain marks beyond a low level 2 response. Some students provided lengthy descriptions of studies such as Watson and Rayner's research using Little Albert but then failed to elaborate on how and why this study supports the two-process model of phobias, thereby gaining little AO3 credit. The best responses to this question focused on fewer evaluations but used these to provide effective elaboration as to how and why the point made either provided support for or criticism of the two-process model of phobias.

QUESTION 10

Many students were able to provide an accurate and somewhat detailed description of systematic desensitisation as a treatment for phobias, with many able to gain a level 2 response which showed a good standard of knowledge of this treatment. The main issue that held some students back was the lack of clarity surrounding all three elements of systematic desensitisation (anxiety hierarchy, relaxation techniques and gradual exposure). Some students either merged some of these elements together or missed one of them out completely. For example, they would often describe the creation of an anxiety hierarchy and how the client is gradually exposed to each stage, starting at the least fearful and moving up. However, they rarely mentioned or clarified the importance of teaching the client how to relax and the important role of relaxation in the treatment process. The best responses to this question clearly explained all three processes and provided a relevant example of how a phobia (eg spiders) might be treated referring to these processes. One other significant issue was the lack of focus on the 'how' element, as stated in the question. Whenever students see the term 'how' within a question then they must ensure they include the process within their response. Some students simply provided an overall definition of the concept of systematic desensitisation without referencing any of the procedures used and such responses were restricted to 1 mark.

QUESTION 11.1

Unfortunately, many students did not engage with the requirement to find the characteristics of depression that Amena displayed in the description of her behaviour and instead, they merely named

two characteristics of depression. Such responses could only gain a maximum of 1 mark. Students need to practise these types of application questions as many struggled to gain more than 1 mark.

QUESTION 11.2

Many students performed well on this question and were able to accurately explain how Amena's conversation with her doctor demonstrated the three components of Beck's negative triad. However, a few seemed to misunderstand the difference between a negative view of the world and a negative view of the future. For example, for a negative view of the world, some students tried to link this to Amena's statement that she believes that nothing will change, and she will feel like this forever. This statement is more closely linked to a negative view of the future since it is related to Amena's views of what she thinks will or will not happen in the future, rather than what is happening now in the world around her.

QUESTION 11.3

As with the other AO3 only questions on this paper, students often struggled to gain marks beyond top level 1 or bottom level 2. There were however some excellent answers that demonstrated a clear understanding of the strengths and/or limitations of the cognitive explanation of depression and used these issues in a clear and effective way. However, many students either identified several relevant evaluations but did not clearly explain how and/or why they were a strength or limitation of the cognitive explanation of depression. Alternatively, some students lost focus on the question and started to write lengthy descriptions about treatments such as cognitive behavioural therapy and how this is used to treat depression, as well as then evaluating CBT. The best responses focused on fewer evaluation issues of the cognitive explanation of depression presented in some depth, with each chosen evaluation issue being clearly explained and effectively linked to how and why it is a strength or limitation for the cognitive explanations of depression.

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